cohort. It has so far not spoken in one voice on the issue. On September 14, veteran Shyam Rajak reprised ex-CM Nitish Kumar's old line: support UCC in Parliament, but keep it out of Bihar. The next day, deputy CM Vijay Chaudhary emphasised process—saying the provisions will be studied. National spokesperson Rajiv Ranjan said working chief Sanjay Jha would meet Shah to discuss the issue. Together, the words circle warily around the issue.

Even for the LJP(RV), the calculation is delicate—and it seems in no rush to commit itself. Seeking clarity on the draft, Chirag said: "India's social fabric is diverse. Every class has its own civic traditions and customs. The Constitution itself has acknowledged this—the Fifth-Sixth Schedules, Articles 371A and 371G, and the exemptions granted to Scheduled Tribes in every code so far are proof of this."



**Takeaways**

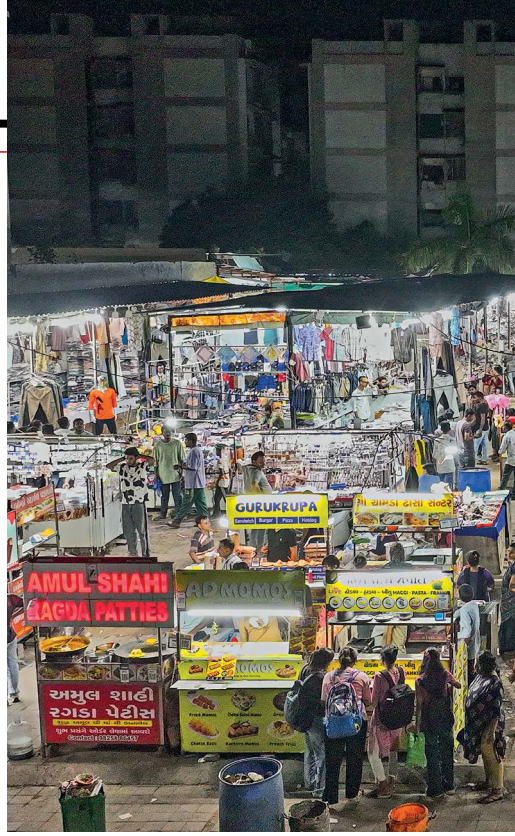
- **No NDA party dismisses Shah proposal, but JD(U) says it will study the draft before deciding**
- **Chirag's LJP cites legal exemptions, says it is stands for "equality and diversity"**
- **Both fear that Muslims may consolidate behind suitors like Prashant Kishor, Tejashwi**

## THE DIVERSITY LOGIC

His words carried weight. The cited articles have a role akin to the now-annulled Article 370 once adjacent to then. They act as legislative brakes for Nagaland and Mizoram, ensuring national laws do not automatically apply if deemed not in consonance with indigenous rights. "My party is committed to equality and diversity," Chirag said, and spoke of consultations that would keep in sight "the interests of all stakeholders" before taking a stand.

Neither party has any incentive to seek confrontation with the BJP, but they have reasons to be wary of its electoral consequences. Muslim alienation has potential beneficiaries in waiting. Tejashwi Yadav's Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) is an old destination. Even if electorally frayed presently, that's no guarantee for the future. Jan Suraaj of Prashant Kishor (PK) is a new suitor. After winning Bankipur, PK has begun urging Bihar's Muslims to seek greater representation. The UCC can halt Muslim dispersal from the RJD's shadow, which had helped the JD(U) and LJP. Tactical consolidation behind PK or RJD could alter electoral equations unfavourably.

For Muslims, the UCC debate is not just about material aspects like inheritance. It represents a final ingress into the right to retain an autonomous space around religion. And in Bihar, their numbers count. That means Shah's deadline sets two political clocks ticking in the state. There's a national passage to the next Lok Sabha election. And mind the chronology: Bihar's next assembly election is due a year later. ■




*By* **Jumana Shah**

**GUJARAT IS GETTING A NIGHT LIFE**—just not the kind people may desire, nor one that brings the dawn of good governance much closer. But the Gujarat Ease of Doing Business Bill, 2026, passed in mid-September, offers the state bragging rights of another sort. Prima facie, it has a feelgood vibe: all shops, restaurants and commercial establishments will be allowed to stay open 24x7. Administratively, too, it's reformist in tenor: claiming to eliminate 'Inspector Raj', embodying PM Narendra Modi's credo of minimum government, maximum governance.

Citizen-friendly, business-friendly. What, then, is the issue? For one, with its wholesale nature, it has much to answer for when it comes to the fine print. It folds amendments to five separate laws into a single legislation. Rather than move five separate bills, the government says it chose to save legislative time—minimum government already. So MLAs rang in changes to not just shop operating hours, but also fire safety regulation, MSME facilitation, medical registration and citizen grievance redress in a single vote.

The demise of Inspector Raj is a virtue worth pursuing in the light of